

**Report On Implementation Of Recommendations
Against Discrimination In Education**

Education Commission

Democratic People's Republic of Korea

2020

Forward

The Democratic People's Republic of Korea (DPRK) has established the well-regulated pre-school system, formal secondary and higher education system, and the informal in-service education and social education system, under which all people in the country enjoy free education.

Upholding the slogan of making people well-versed in science and technology, the DPRK Government takes several measures to ensure that all people have free access to life-long education to their hearts' content.

In line with the demand of times the DPRK Government makes positive efforts to put education on IT and modern basis as early as possible, to improve the content and methods of education, to upgrade the conditions and environment of education, and to bring about a fresh turn in secondary general and other levels of education.

In addition, it works hard to raise its level of education to the advanced world level as soon as possible in closer cooperation with UNESCO, UNICEF and other international organizations.

The 1960 Convention and Recommendations against Discrimination in Education which underlines the important global norms for the right to education reflect the mission of UNESCO in its Charter to promote the ideal of equitable access to education without discrimination based on racial, gender and other economic and social differences.

Education 2030 Agenda set the SDG of ensuring inclusive and equitable quality education and promoting lifelong learning opportunities for all and its related objectives.

Since the adoption of Education 2030 Agenda, the DPRK has drawn nation-wide public attention to dynamically step up the effort to ensure inclusive and equitable quality education and promote lifelong learning opportunities for all and its related objectives

This report includes the achievements and experience gained by DPRK in implementing the goal of Education 2030 Agenda in the period of 2017 to 2020, in conformity with Article 8 of UNESCO Charter which requires that each of its member states presents its regular report on the measures taken by it to implement the conventions and recommendation adopted by UNESCO.

1. Legal Foundation for Educational Development

Implementation of the education policies pursued by the DPRK Government is firmly ensured by the Socialist Constitution of the DPRK, the Law of the DPRK on Education and other laws for different sectors.

The Socialist Constitution of the DPRK was adopted at the First Session of the Fifth Supreme People's Assembly on Dec. 27, 1972 and subsequently it was revised and supplemented on nine occasions to meet the requirement of the times in its development.

The DPRK adopted the Law on Nursing and Upbringing of Children at the Sixth Session of the Fifth Supreme People's Assembly on April 29, 1976. Then, it adopted the Law of the DPRK on Education, the Law of the DPRK on General Education, the Law of the DPRK on Higher Education, the Law of the DPRK on Teachers, the Law of the DPRK on Technical and Vocational Education and the Law of the DPRK on the Implementation of Education Programme by decrees of the Presidium of the Supreme People's Assembly. It also adopted the Law of the DPRK on Distance Education as a decree of the Supreme People's Assembly.

The Sixth Session of the twelfth Supreme People's Assembly held on Sept. 25, 2012 adopted the decree of the Supreme People's Assembly On the Introduction of Universal 12-year Compulsory Education.

The Socialist Constitution, the specific laws for education and the decrees of the DPRK are the concentrated reflection of the education policies of the state.

The DPRK has stipulated by law that all its citizens have the obligation for compulsory secondary general education and the right to free education.

The obligation of the entire population for secondary general education and the right to free education constitute the most basic guarantee for the implementation of the Education 2030 Agenda targeting inclusive and equitable education.

Article 45 of the Socialist Constitution of the DPRK stipulates, "The state shall develop the universal 12-year compulsory education including 1-year

pre-school education at high level to meet the trend of the development of modern science and technology and the practical requirements of socialist construction”, and Article 47 reads, “The state shall provide all students with free access to education and give scholarship to students of universities and specialized schools ”.

The Law of the DPRK on Education adopted by Decree No. 847 of the Presidium of the Supreme People’s Assembly on July 14, 1999 and revised and supplemented on Dec. 23, 2015 reads: All DPRK citizens shall have the obligation for secondary general education and the right to free education. All forms of education is free in the DPRK. Any educational establishment shall be prohibited to receive any fee for admission, lessons, internship, study tour and excursion from any student, his or her parents, or his or her guardian.

The DPRK defined by law that special attention shall be paid to the provision of technical and vocational education to all its citizens according to their hopes and aptitudes, as well as to women and people with disabilities.

Creation of all necessary conditions for all citizens, particularly women and persons with disabilities, to have access to technical and vocational education according to their hopes and aptitudes is one of the important factors for the implementation of the 1960 Convention and Recommendations on equitable access to education without discrimination based on racial, gender and other economic and social differences.

The Law of the DPRK on Technical and Vocational Education adopted by Decree No. 2315 of the Presidium of the Supreme People’s Assembly on July 12, 2018 stipulates that the state shall create all necessary conditions for all its citizens to have access to vocational and technical education according to their hopes and aptitudes and pay special attention to that for women and people with disabilities.

With the adoption of the Law of the DPRK on Technical and Vocational Education, the DPRK has provided a firm legal guarantee for the access of all its citizens to vocational and technical education.

The DPRK has made it law to promote social education and provide all necessary conditions for learning to all its working people.

Promotion of social education is an important way to implement the SDG for the creation of opportunity for lifelong education for all.

The Socialist Constitution of the DPRK reads: The state shall promote social education and provide all its working people with all necessary conditions for learning.

The Law of the DPRK on Distance Education adopted by the Presidium of the Supreme People's Assembly on April 12, 2020 includes the provision that the well-regulated distance education system and order shall be established for all members of society to have access to higher education while working with a view to contributing to making all people well-versed in science and technology and turning the country into a power of talents.

The Law of the DPRK on Distance Education defines its mission, establishment of distance education system, enrollment of students, formulation of the distance education programme and its implementation, provision of conditions for it and all other issues related to distance education.

The DPRK has adopted a law on providing in a responsible way the conditions for education and life of parentless children or those without guardians, the children with disabilities in seeing and hearing and other disabilities at the expense of the state.

The Law of the DPRK on General Education adopted by the Decision No. 1355 of the Presidium of the Supreme People's Assembly on Jan. 19, 2011 and revised and supplemented on Dec. 23, 2015 provides that the state shall be responsible for the conditions of education and living for parentless children or those without guardians, children with disabilities in seeing, hearing and speaking and other disabilities.

Since the first day of its founding, DPRK has taken legal and institutional measures for preferential treatment and protection of persons with disabilities at

the expense of the state.

The Law of the DPRK on Protection of Persons with Disabilities adopted by Decree No. 3835 of the Presidium of the Supreme People's Assembly on June 18, 2003 and amended on Nov. 21, 2013 provides the fundamentals for education of the persons with disabilities, the registration and care of pre-school children with disabilities, their enrollment, their right to higher education, organization and operation of special schools for them, formulation of educational programme for them, publication of special educational materials for them, organization and management of vocational schools for them, and development of the braille and sign language. It also includes the provisions to form special classes in general schools or establish special schools like schools for persons with disabilities in hearing and seeing and mental cultivation schools according to their physical mental characteristics and types of disabilities. It also stipulates that students of special schools shall be given scholarship.

With the adoption of the Law of the DPRK on General Education and the Law of the DPRK on Protection of Persons with Disabilities, the DPRK has laid a firm legal foundation for parentless children or those without guardians, children with disabilities in seeing, hearing and speaking and other disabilities to have the same obligation and access to education as normal children and make positive contributions to the development of society.

The DPRK acceded to the "Marrakesh Treaty to facilitate access to publish works for persons who are blind, visually impaired, or otherwise print disabled" on May 19, 2016.

2. Improved Qualification of Teaching Staff

For the implementation of the SDG for equitable access to inclusive and equitable education of high quality envisaged in Education 2030 Agenda, it is essential to improve the qualification of teaching staff who are directly responsible for it.

With the view that bringing about a radical turn in education is immediately improving the qualification of teaching staff, the DPRK Government has directed great efforts to the latter and attached nation-wide, social importance to it.

It has ensured that all universities of education and teachers training colleges take measures to update their teaching programme and improve the quality of education in an innovative way to produce highly qualified teachers.

It also ensured that the primary and secondary education sectors enroll all school teachers, including those of rural and mountainous areas, in refreshment courses and distance education system to improve their qualification to meet the requirement of the development of education.

The state has channeled great efforts to narrowing the gap between urban and rural areas in secondary education.

Since 2018, it has established the system, under which the graduates of universities of education and teachers training colleges are engaged in teaching at schools in rural and mountainous areas. Meanwhile, it has encouraged them to volunteer to them in order to consolidate the teaching staff there. From 2017 to 2020 more than 800 graduates of the teachers training institutions volunteered to the branch schools in remote mountainous areas and solitary islets.

For the improvement of education for children with disabilities in seeing, hearing and speaking and other disabilities, it is important to train teachers capable for special education. It is not only aimed at improving the quality of special education, but also at ensuring that all the people with disabilities make positive contribution to social development with the rights equal to other people.

The DPRK Government now works hard to the qualification of teachers at schools for children with disabilities in seeing, hearing and speaking, for example, it has set up the center for training teachers of their schools.

3. Perfection of Education System

The DPRK Government ensures that the secondary general education system

is improved and consolidated in line with the requirement of social development.

DPRK has introduced the universal 12-year compulsory education since April 1, 2014. This system provides compulsory and free secondary general education to all children and students of the 5~17 age group throughout the country..

The DPRK has set up technical senior middle schools in the metallurgical, coal-mining, chemical, electrical, fishing, agricultural, fruit farming and stockbreeding fields, and since April 1, 2017, has ensured that senior middle school students receive basic technical education which suits the economical and geographical features of the regions in which they live.

In 2018 it established 11 IT senior middle schools on an experimental basis, and in 2020, with the experience gained from their operation, it formed IT classes at 195 senior middle schools across the country.

The DPRK Government has improved and consolidated the special education system, under which all the people with disabilities acquire the knowledge, skills and arts so that they can contribute to the state and social development with the obligations and rights equal to other people.

With the increase of universal compulsory education course from 11 to 12 years, all the schools for children with disabilities in seeing, hearing and speaking have also began to implement the 12- year programme like other schools since April 1, 2016.

The DPRK Government saw to it that the number of higher education institutions be increased to meet the requirement of the effort to make all people well-versed in science and technology.

Since 2017 the number of factory, farm and fishermen's colleges has increased, and tens of technical and vocational colleges have been newly established more.

The DPRK Government has also taken measure to expand the distance education courses and improve their quality, and thus hundreds of thousands working people are now involved in the distance education system to acquire the

scientific and technical knowledge conducive to their own production activities.

4. Innovation of Teaching Content and Methods

For inclusive and equitable quality education, the SDG included in Education 2030 Agenda, it is imperative to constantly innovate teaching content and methods as required by the requirement of the times.

The DPRK Government directs great efforts to formulating and implementing the universal 12-year compulsory education programme of higher standard.

It has made comprehensive analysis of the issues arising in the implementation of the universal 12-year compulsory education programme, and on that basis, actively encouraged schools to make education practical and modern, increase the proportion of practice and improve the teaching content and methods in a proactive way.

It has ensured that technical senior middle schools formulate and implement a new education programme so that their students can get different forms of practical education suited to the economic and geographical features of their own regions.

It also defined the new teaching content of the schools for children with disabilities in seeing, hearing and speaking in 2016. In particular, it has ensured that they update the content of IT and basic technical education as required by the developing reality so that their students can get jobs in IT and other sectors after graduation and make their own service to social development.

Improvement of teaching methods is essential for giving quality education to all students.

The DPRK Government has paid special attention to improvement of teaching methods at schools in the rural and mountainous areas.

It has tried hard to assist in different forms and ways the teachers in the rural and mountainous areas in their preparation for lessons and improvement of their qualification: in 2017 it sent over 6, 600 teachers in the urban areas to the schools in the rural and mountainous areas to show them the demonstration lessons for

about 45,000 hours and organized for more than 6,900 teachers in the rural and mountainous areas the observation of lessons given by the excellent teachers in urban areas. It has also made positive contributions to the improvement of teaching methods by providing educational multimedia and video materials of model lessons to them on a regular basis.

Inclusive and equitable quality education presupposes the educational environment in which high level of education is given to students according to their aptitudes and talents.

Schools of different forms have formed various circles of after-school activities to suit their specific features so that all students can fully develop their talent according to their aptitudes and talents. Throughout the country more than 49,200 circles are now in operation for physics, chemistry, robotics, IT, Go, embroidery, etc.

In addition, according to the measures taken by the state, universities and schools of all other levels have increased the duration of summer vacation, in which they organize self-study, visits, study tour and other extracurricular activities.

To put education on more solid IT and scientific basis is important to ensure quality education.

In 2017 Kim Hyong Jik University of Education, Kim Chaek University of Technology and other major universities with strong educational and scientific research forces have newly set up multimedia research sections which specialize in research and production of multimedia for primary and secondary education: they produce educational multimedia necessary for all subjects at schools of different forms in implementing the universal 12-year compulsory education programme and distribute them to general education institutions, particularly to those in the rural and mountainous areas, helping them to raise their level of IT application to teaching.

Homepage exclusively for education has been opened to distribute practical

and good teaching methods to all schools across the country through it, thus contributing to narrowing the gap between urban and rural areas.

And they produced video multimedia for primary, junior and senior middle schools to be distributed to all students throughout the country so that they can do proper self-study while strictly observing the anti-epidemic rules to prevent the inflow and spread of COVID-19.

The DPRK Government pays profound attention to providing parentless children with the conditions for their learning and living.

It has built halls, gymnasiums and other facilities for after-school activities at primary and secondary boarding schools and provided them with musical instruments, sports apparatuses, embroidery kits and other means for after-school activities.

All students of primary and secondary boarding schools are involved in different circles according to their aptitudes and desire. Every year they are taking part in academic, art and sports contests, giving full play to their talents and abilities.

Since 2017 the state has regularly organized refreshment courses for teachers of the schools for children with disabilities in seeing, hearing and speaking and showed them demonstration lessons of other schools, thus improving the quality of education at special schools.

5. Improvement of Educational Conditions and Environment

The DPRK Government has made energetic efforts to raise the material and technological foundation of education onto the world standard by upgrading the educational conditions and environment.

It has continued to pay deep attention and channel great efforts to providing better educational environment to all its citizens.

Improvement of educational environment as required by the century is to create material preconditions for inclusive and equitable quality education, the

SDG included in Education 2030 Agenda.

Above all, the DPRK Government has made dynamic efforts to provide better environment for social education to all its citizens.

In January 2016, it built, as a model of social education center, the Sci-Tech Complex, the palace of education for all and the multi-functional scientific and technological knowledge extension center. Then, all establishments, enterprises, factories and cooperative farms have linked their own scientific and technological knowledge extension rooms on-line to the Sci-Tech Complex and operated them on a regular basis so that all working people update scientific and technological knowledge while working and make positive contributions to the technological development of their own units.

Now the Sci-Tech Complex is open to students ranging from primary schools to universities, teachers, researchers and all other citizens. They also acquire modern scientific and technological knowledge on-line.

It has rebuilt the children's camps and schoolchildren's palaces in a modern way to provide better, pleasant environment for camping life and after-school activities to all children.

And since 2017, according to the year-to-year plan, it has newly built or rebuilt schools of general education in a modern way and turned all classrooms into multifunctional ones.

In particular, it has made full investigation into the conditions of school buildings in the rural and mountainous areas and provided necessary labour, materials and fund preferentially to them. Accordingly, since 2017 hundreds of schools have been newly built or modernized every year. And all schools are connected to the national network so that they can share educational resources.

It built, as models of teachers training centers, Pyongyang Teachers Training College in 2017 and Kanggye Teachers Training College in 2019. With them as an example, each of the provinces is now stepping up the construction of its teachers training college at the final stage.

In addition, **Kim Il Sung** University and other universities have newly built or rebuilt their buildings in a modern way, e-libraries and dormitories, and equipped themselves with computers and other modern teaching means in a proactive way, thus raising the training of talents onto a higher phase.

Up to 2018 the DPRK Government has newly built 9 children's homes, 10 primary boarding schools and 10 secondary boarding schools, and ensured that they are provided with vegetable and fruit on a regular basis to improve nutritional management there.

It produces not only textbooks but also quality schoolbags and provides them to all children and students for next to nothing.

In 2020 it newly built the Educational Books Printing House furnished with modern printing equipment to provide enough textbooks, reference books and reading materials to students. In 2017 it built modern Mindulle Notebooks Factory for the production of notebooks exclusively for all children and students ranging from kindergartens to universities across the country, and has steadily increased its production capacity.

Besides, it built Pyongyang Bag Factory in 2017 for the production of male and female schoolbags of different kinds, to be followed by other modern bag factories in 13 provinces across the country, thus providing quality schoolbags to students.

The DPRK provides all necessary conditions to all school-aged children with disabilities at the expense of the state. In particular, the students of special schools receives scholarships as university students do and get food, uniforms and school-things free of charge.

Conclusion

This report is made on the basis of the achievements and experiences gained by the DPRK Government from 2017 to 2020 in its effort to attain the goal of “ensure inclusive and equitable quality education and promote life-long learning opportunities for all” included in Education 2030 Agenda.

For the last 4 years DPRK has channeled primary efforts to improvement of teachers’ qualification and actively promoted perfection of education system, innovation of teaching content and methods and upgrading of educational conditions and environment.

In spite of the great successes it has made during the period under review, there still exists considerable gap between schools in rural and urban areas in terms of education quality and conditions and it still has several difficulties in creating full education conditions and environment for the schools of the children with disabilities in seeing, hearing and speaking and other disabilities and classes for groups of the children with disabilities.

At present DPRK is faced with the heavy task to thoroughly implement the new National Education Development Strategy and its high objectives.

As in the past so also in future, the DPRK Government will further develop education to meet the latest trend of education development and pedagogical requirements and raise its education to the world advanced level as soon as possible by making dynamic efforts to attain the goal of Education 2030 Agenda to ensure inclusive and equitable access to quality education and create more opportunities for lifelong learning for all in close cooperation with UNESCO, UNICEF and other international organizations.